

Engagement Trap

Flattery Trap was approval feeling like help. Engagement Trap is the conversation never quite ending.

You ask AI a quick question. You get a clear answer. Then, casually attached at the end: *“Want me to expand on this? Should I add examples? Want me to format it as a study guide?”* You weren’t going to ask any of that. You were done. The reply doesn’t seem to be.

This is the move that turns a one-question chat into a six-message tour. Sometimes the offers help. Often they don’t. **A follow-up is an option, not an assignment.**

 THE WORD

Continuation Loop

A reply pattern that keeps the conversation going after the original task may already be done.

Common moves: offering a follow-up, asking a clarifying question, volunteering a next step, leaving the door open with “let me know if...” The loop isn’t always bad. The trap is forgetting you get to decide whether to continue.

THE PATTERN IN THE WILD



The “Want me to...” offer

Your answer is done. The reply has wrapped. Then: “Want me to expand this, give examples, or write a follow-up?” The chat doesn’t end. It pitches another chat.



The clarifying-question stall

You asked something straightforward. Instead of answering, AI asks four questions back. Sometimes useful. Sometimes a stall that turns one prompt into a whole tour.



The volunteered next step

You asked for a summary. You got a summary, plus flashcards, a study guide, and a practice quiz on offer. None of which you asked for. All of which sound helpful.

 **AI’s habit of continuing isn’t an accident.** Assistants are trained and tuned to be helpful in conversation. They learn patterns like clarifying questions, offered next steps, and leaving the door open. Those patterns can help. They can also make a finished task feel unfinished.

DON’T OVERCORRECT

Once you spot the pattern, it’s tempting to flag every follow-up as manipulation and clip every reply at the first period. Don’t. Sometimes the clarifying question is exactly what your messy prompt needed. Sometimes “Want me to give an example?” is the example you actually wanted. The skill isn’t refusing engagement. It’s noticing it, and choosing whether you want it.

STOP THE LOOP

Sometimes the offer is useful. When it isn’t, name it in your prompt and the loop stops.

Three moves when you want the chat to end.

1 **Ask for one thing only.**

When you want the answer with no extras, tell the model to skip the follow-up offers.

`“Answer the question directly. Don’t offer follow-ups or next steps.”`

2 **Pre-empt the clarifying stall.**

When your prompt is clear and the model still asks four questions back, tell it to assume and go.

`“Draft this without asking clarifying questions first. Make reasonable assumptions and note any you made.”`

3 **Close the door yourself.**

When you’re done, end the chat. The model won’t suggest closing. That call is always yours.

 A follow-up is an option, not an obligation. More chat is not more progress. Continue on purpose, not by momentum.